

2.3 Creating And Using .Reg Files

Now that you have an understanding of how the Registry operates, you are ready to start hacking it! Hackers are not just those who create malicious viruses or attempt to break into systems. In fact, anyone who decides to get under the hood of any system to discover how it works, tweaks it to gain some advantage, or does it just out of curiosity to see what happens when something is changed, can be considered as a hacker. The hacker is more interested in the mechanics of the hack rather than the result. Once you get into the Registry and change things around, you may want to create your own .reg files to distribute to friends or publish it on your Web site or blog. Use this capability with caution, and be extra sure of what you are doing. A wrong entry here can potentially wreak havoc on a user's system.

The .reg file is actually a text file which will open in any ASCII editor like Notepad. It uses a specific syntax that the registry recognizes. Following the rules of this syntax you can create and publish your own registry hack.

The .reg file uses the syntax:

RegistryEditorVersion

Blank line

[RegistryPath1]

"DataItemName1"="DataType1:DataValue1"

"DataItemName2"="DataType2:DataValue2"

Blank line

[RegistryPath2]

"DataItemName3"="DataType3:DataValue3"

For Windows XP and Windows 2000, the header **RegistryEditorVersion** should always read "Windows Registry Editor Version 5.00". You can also create .reg files for use on older Windows 98 and Windows NT4.0 systems. **REGEDIT4** is the version entry in the header of the .reg file for Windows 98 and NT4.0 systems. A .reg file with the **REGEDIT4** header will work both on